From Prompt to Response

An End-to-End Journey Inside LLM and RAG Systems

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Chapter 1

From Prompt to Response

An End-to-End Journey Inside LLM and RAG Systems

Part I

When the Word is Spoken Into the Void

Chapter 2

the intro

Part II

The Summoning of the Request

Chapter 3

APIs and Model Serving

The canonical question for this chapter: *A trained model is a file on a disk. How does it become something millions of people can query simultaneously, with low latency, high reliability, and predictable cost?*

Figure 3.1: The journey through the Model Mind.

The prompt has been written and structured. Now it needs to travel somewhere. This chapter covers everything between the user pressing Enter and the model receiving the request: the wire format, the serving infrastructure, and the engineering decisions that make large-scale LLM deployment economical. :::

3.1 The gap between training and deployment

Training produces a checkpoint: a collection of weight tensors saved to disk. At this point, the model can do nothing on its own. It has no interface. It cannot receive requests. It does not know what a user is.

Turning that checkpoint into a production service requires solving a completely different set of engineering problems from those that were involved in training. During training, we try to optimize for producing as many tokens as possible per second. On the other hand, during serving, the optimization focuses on latency, concurrency, reliability, and cost, which means we want to respond to requests quickly, serve many users simultaneously, remain available under failure, and do all of this economically.

These requirements require a different approach. The same GPU cluster that runs training efficiently is not automatically an efficient serving infrastructure. Serving is its own engineering discipline, with its own abstractions, its own failure modes, and its own optimization techniques.

This chapter covers the full stack from trained checkpoint to the API endpoint a user or application calls.

3.2 The anatomy of an LLM API

The standard interface for production LLM services is an HTTP API, almost universally following the conventions established by OpenAI's API.

3.2.1 The chat completions endpoint

The primary endpoint for most production use:

`POST /v1/chat/completions`

Request body:

```
{
  "model": "gpt-4o",
  "messages": [
    {"role": "system", "content": "You are a helpful assistant."},
    {"role": "user", "content": "What is the capital of France?"}
  ],
  "max_tokens": 100,
  "temperature": 0.7,
  "stream": false
}
```

Response:

```
{
  "id": "chatcmpl-abc123",
  "object": "chat.completion",
  "created": 1699000000,
  "model": "gpt-4o",
  "choices": [
    {
      "index": 0,
      "message": {
        "role": "assistant",
        "content": "The capital of France is Paris."
      },
      "finish_reason": "stop"
    }
  ],
  "usage": {
    "prompt_tokens": 26,
    "completion_tokens": 9,
    "total_tokens": 35
  }
}
```

Several design decisions in this interface iluminates the realities of LLM serving:

Messages array instead of a single string. Conversations have a clear structure consisting of a system prompt, user turns, and assistant turns. The API explicitly defines the structure, instead of relying on concatenated strings and expecting the model to interpret the formatting correctly.

Token counts in the response. Because LLM cost and latency are proportional to token count, the API reports exactly how many tokens were consumed allowing costs to be monitored and controlled programmatically.

`finish_reason`. Why did the model stop generating? `stop` means it produced an end-of-sequence token. `length`

means it reached the `max_tokens`. `content_filter` means the response was filtered. These signals help to determine whether the response is complete

`stream` parameter. Whether to stream tokens as they are generated or return the complete response when done. Streaming is architecturally significant and covered in detail in chapter "REFF".

3.2.2 The completions endpoint (legacy)

An older interface that takes the raw string prompt rather than the structured messages array:

```
{
  "model": "gpt-3.5-turbo-instruct",
  "prompt": "The capital of France is",
  "max_tokens": 10
}
```

This endpoint represents an earlier era of LLM deployment, when models were not chat tuned and the interface was closer to a text continuation service. It is still useful for non-chat use cases but has been superseded by chat completions for most applications.

3.2.3 Key parameters

`temperature` controls the randomness of sampling. At temperature 0, the model always selects the most likely next token (greedy decoding). At temperature 1, it samples from a full distribution. Above 1, the distribution flattens, producing more random and unstable outputs. Temperature interacts with the decoding strategy covered in chapter "REFF".

`top_p` (nucleus sampling) this is an alternative to temperature for controlling randomness. The model samples from the smallest set of tokens in which the cumulative probability exceeds `top_p`. Setting `top_p = 0.9` restricts sampling to tokens that together account for 90% of the probability mass that means the long tail of unlikely tokens is ignored.

`max_tokens` sets the maximum number of tokens to generate. It functions as a cost and latency cap. If the model reaches this limit before producing a stop token, `finish_reason` is `length` and the response may be end mid-sentence.

Stop sequences are one or more strings that cause halt in generation immediately if the model produces them. They are useful for structured generation where you know the output should end at a specific delimiter.

`frequency_penalty` and `presence_penalty` discourage repetition. `frequency_penalty` applies a penalty proportional to how many time a token has already appeared. `presence_penalty` applies a flat penalty to any token that has appeared at all. Both help the model to prevent from getting stuck in repetitive loops.

`n` specifies how many independent completions to generate for a single prompt. Useful for best-of-n sampling where you generate multiple responses and select the best one.

`logprobs` returns the log probabilities of the selected tokens and also the top-k most likely tokens at each position. It is used for calibration, analysis, and classification tasks where you care more about the model's confidence, not just its output.

3.3 From checkpoint to serving: the loading pipeline

Before a model can serve requests, it must be loaded. For a model with hundreds of billions of parameters, this is a nontrivial task.

3.3.1 Checkpoint format and sharding

Training checkpoints are often sharded due to the fact that the full model does not fit in the memory of a single storage node or loading process. A 70B parameter model in BF16 requires approximately 140 GB of storage and Loading it

into a GPU memory requires careful orchestration.

Common checkpoint formats:

- **PyTorch `.pt` / `.bin`**: the standard PyTorch format which can be slow to load due to pickle deserialization
- **SafeTensors**: a faster and safer alternative which can be loaded significantly faster via memory-mapped files
- **GGUF**: a format used by llama.cpp, optimized for inference on consumer hardware and it is able to quantize weights natively

3.3.2 Quantization for serving

Training typically utilizes BF16 weights (2 bytes per parameter). For serving, quantization reduces this further:

INT8 quantization stores weights as 8-bit integers (1 byte per parameter). This achieves a 2× memory reduction which causes a small quality loss that is mostly negligible for generation tasks.

INT4 quantization uses 4-bit integers (0.5 bytes per parameter) for a 4× memory reduction. Causes more quality loss and needs careful calibration. Enables running 70B models on consumer GPUs that could not otherwise fit them.

GPTQ is a post-training quantization technique that calibrates 4-bit quantization using a small dataset, minimizing quality loss from reduced precision.

AWQ (Activation-aware Weight Quantization) quantizes weights while accounting for the distribution of activations, producing better results than naive quantization at the same bit width.

The tradeoff is consistent: the quantization reduces memory requirements while increase throughput, at the cost of some output quality. For production serving where cost matters, INT8 is nearly universal. INT4 is used when memory is severely constrained or when we want to serve on consumer hardware.

3.3.3 Tensor parallelism for large models

A 405B parameter model in BF16 requires approximately 810 GB of GPU memory that is far beyond a single GPU's capacity. In these scenarios, loading requires distributing the model across multiple GPUs using tensor parallelism (splitting individual weight matrices across GPUs) or pipeline parallelism (assigning different layers to different GPUs).

The same parallelism strategies used in training apply to serving, but with different constraints: training prioritizes throughput (large batches, high utilization), while serving prioritizes latency (fast first-token generation, smaller batches).

3.4 The serving architecture

3.4.1 The inference server

The core component: a process that holds the model weights in GPU memory and handles requests. The major implementations:

vLLM is the dominant open-source inference server. It introduces PagedAttention (covered in detail in chapter "REFF") for efficient KV cache management, and supports tensor parallelism, continuous batching, and most major model architectures.

TensorRT-LLM (NVIDIA) is NVIDIA's inference optimization library. It applies kernel fusion, INT8/FP8 quantization, and hardware-specific optimizations. Typically the fastest option on NVIDIA hardware but requires compilation for specific model shapes which is a trade between flexibility and performance.

llama.cpp is a pure C++ implementation of LLaMA-family models, optimized for CPU and consumer GPU inference. Not competitive with vLLM for high-throughput serving, but it is unmatched for accessibility and local deployment.

3.4.2 The API gateway

In front of the inference server sits the API layer:

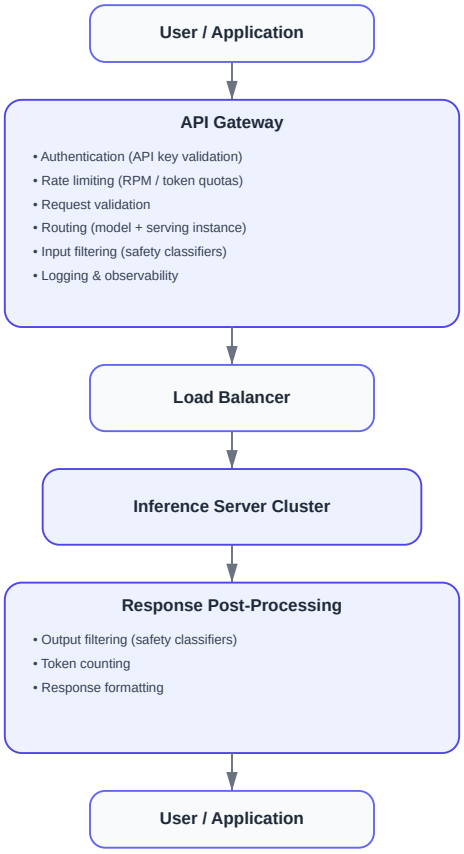

Figure 3.2: The API gateway.

The API gateway is not a performance bottleneck what it does is to process the metadata. It is critical for security (authentication prevents unauthorized access), cost control (rate limiting prevents abuse), reliability (routing distributes traffic and handles failures), and observability (logging every request enables debugging and billing).

3.5 Batching: the key to serving efficiently

A single inference server instance can handle many requests simultaneously. How it batches those requests together affects throughput and GPU utilization.

3.5.1 Naive static batching

The simplest approach is to wait until you have `batch_size` requests, process them together, return all results.

The problem is that LLM generation is variable length. On request might generate 10 tokens while the other might generate 500. In a static batch, all requests must wait for the longest one to finish. GPU utilization drops as shorter requests complete and their slots sit idle, waiting.

3.5.2 Continuous batching

The key innovation for efficient LLM serving, introduced by [1] and popularized by vLLM.

Instead of batching at the request level, continuous batching operates at the iteration level meaning it happens at every token generation step. After each token is generated:

1. Check which sequences in the current batch have finished
2. Remove finished sequences from the batch
3. Add new incoming requests to fill the freed slots
4. Run the next generation step on the updated batch

```
Step 1: [A , B , C ]         ← three requests, first token
Step 2: [A , B , C ]
Step 3: [A , B , C_stop]     ← C finishes after 3 tokens
Step 3: [A , B , D ]         ← D immediately fills C's slot
Step 4: [A , B , D ]
Step 5: [A_stop, B , D ]     ← A finishes
Step 5: [E , B , D ]         ← E fills A's slot
```

The GPU is always processing a full batch. None of the slots sit idle waiting for the longest sequence to finish. On real workloads, this approach can improve throughput by 2 to 3 times compared to a naive static batching. Continuous batching requires careful KV cache management which explains why PagedAttention exists.

3.5.3 Prefill and decode phases

LLM generation has two distinct phases with different compute profiles:

Prefill: processing the input prompt. All prompt tokens are processed in parallel. This phase is compute bound and the bottleneck is GPU arithmetic throughput.

Decode: generating output tokens one at a time. Each step processes one single new token, attending to all previous tokens via the KV cache. This phase is memory-bandwidth-bound and the bottleneck is reading the model weights and KV cache from GPU memory.

Because prefill and decode have different bottlenecks, mixing them in the same batch is not optimal. **Chunked prefill** and **disaggregated serving** are emerging techniques that separate prefill and decode across different hardware or batch slots to maximize utilization of each phase independently.

3.6 KV cache management

The KV cache stores the key and value tensors computed for each previous token, avoiding recomputation on every generation step. It is the central memory management challenge in serving, and will be explained in chapter “REFF”.

A brief introduction here, because it directly constrains serving architecture:

For a model with `L` layers, `h` KV heads, `d_k` key/value dimension, and a sequence of length `n`:

```
KV cache size = 2 × L × h × d_k × n × bytes_per_element
```

For LLaMA 2 70B (L=80, h=8 GQA heads, d_k=128) in BF16:

```
Per token: 2 × 80 × 8 × 128 × 2 = 327,680 bytes   320 KB
4,096 tokens: 320 KB × 4,096   1.3 GB
32,768 tokens: 320 KB × 32,768   10.5 GB
```

At high concurrency with long contexts, KV cache competes directly with model weights for GPU memory.

3.6.1 PagedAttention

The key innovation in vLLM, inspired by virtual memory paging in operating systems.

Traditional KV cache reserves a contiguous memory block for each sequence, sized to accommodate the maximum possible length. This causes internal fragmentation (reserved memory that goes unused when sequences are shorter than expected) and external fragmentation (free memory that cannot be used because it is not contiguous).

PagedAttention allocates KV cache in fixed-size pages of tokens, with a page table mapping logical sequence positions to physical memory locations. Memory is allocated and freed one page at a time as sequences grow and complete:

```
Sequence A: [Page 3, Page 7, Page 12]     ← pages need not be contiguous
Sequence B: [Page 1, Page 9]
Sequence C: [Page 2, Page 4, Page 5, Page 11]
Free pages: [Page 6, Page 8, Page 10, ...]
```

This will eliminates fragmentation and enables an almost perfect memory utilization. It also enables prefix sharing which means if two requests share a common system prompt, the KV cache for that prefix can be shared across both sequences without duplication.

3.7 Latency and throughput tradeoffs

Serving performance is characterized by two metrics that pull against each other:

Time to first token (TTFT) is how long the user waits before seeing any output. This is determined primarily by prefill time and since longer prompts take longer to prefill it is the metric users perceive most directly.

Time between tokens (TBT) is how fast tokens arrive after the first one. This is determined by decode speed. For a 70B model on a single A100, 20 to 60 tokens per second is typically expected.

Throughput is total tokens processed per second across all concurrent requests. Maximized by large batch sizes, which directly conflict with low TTFT.

Production systems manage this tradeoff through maximum batch size limits (cap batch size to maintain acceptable latency), priority queuing (prioritize interactive requests over batch workloads), and SLA-based scheduling (different latency targets for different user tiers).

3.8 Key takeaways

- A trained model checkpoint becomes a production service through a pipeline involving quantization, multi-GPU loading, an inference server, and an API gateway, since training and serving are distinct engineering disciplines
- The chat completions API format, including the messages array, key parameters, and token usage reporting, reflects the practical realities of LLM serving rather than arbitrary design choices
- Continuous batching operates at the token level rather than the request level, keeping GPUs fully utilized despite variable-length generation and serving as the main efficiency improvement for high-throughput systems
- KV cache memory is the central serving constraint because it grows with sequence length and batch size and competes directly with model weights for GPU memory, while PagedAttention manages it using virtual memory paging
- Prefill is compute bound and decode is memory bandwidth bound, so they have fundamentally different performance profiles and can be optimized independently
- TTFT and throughput trade off against each other, and the appropriate balance depends on whether the system serves interactive applications or batch workloads

---

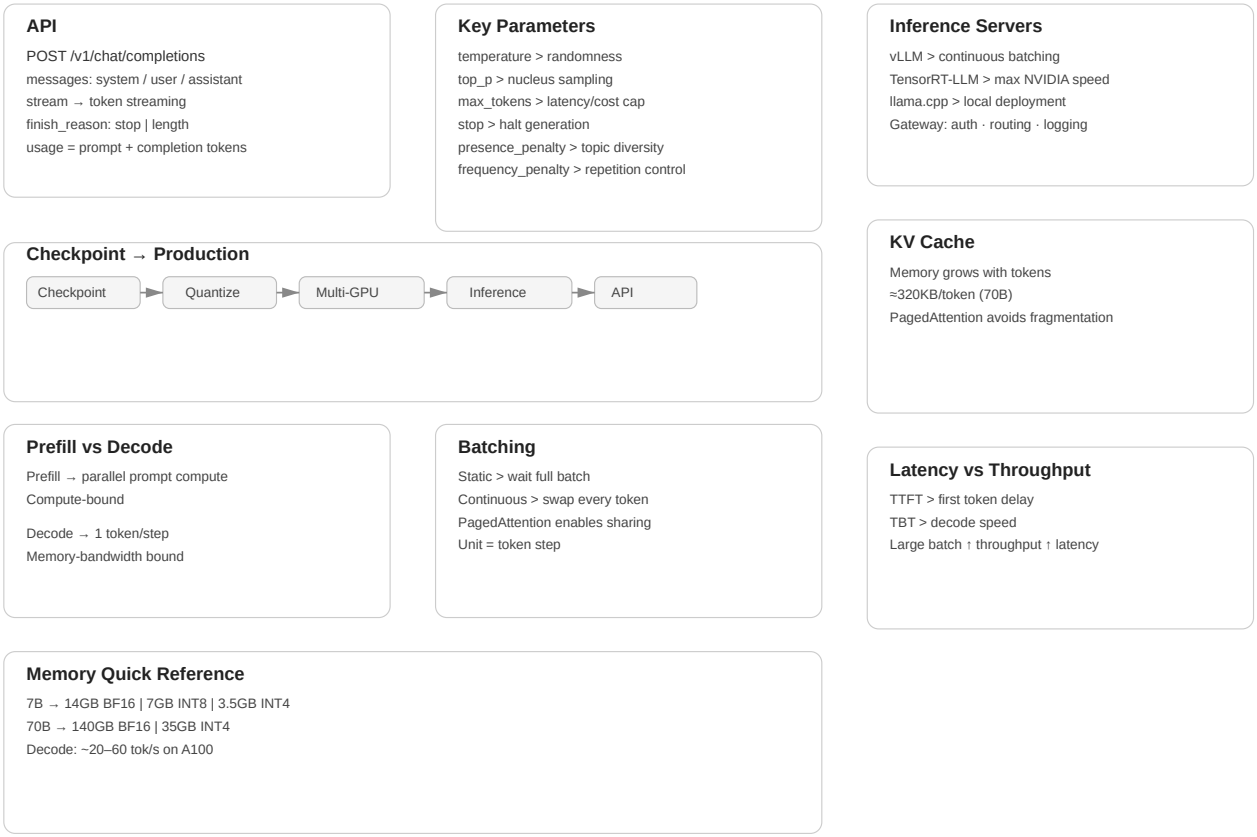

Figure 3.3: Cheat sheet.

3.9 Further reading

- Yu et al. (2022). *Orca: A Distributed Serving System for Transformer-Based Generative Models.*: Introduces continuous batching.
- Kwon et al. (2023). *Efficient Memory Management for Large Language Model Serving with PagedAttention.*: The vLLM paper; foundational for modern serving.

← *Previous: 02 — Prompt engineering and structure*
Next: 04 — Tokenization →

Chapter 4

Tokenization

The canonical question for this chapter: *A user sends a message while a model receive and returns numbers. How does text become numbers on the way in, and how do numbers become text on the way out?*

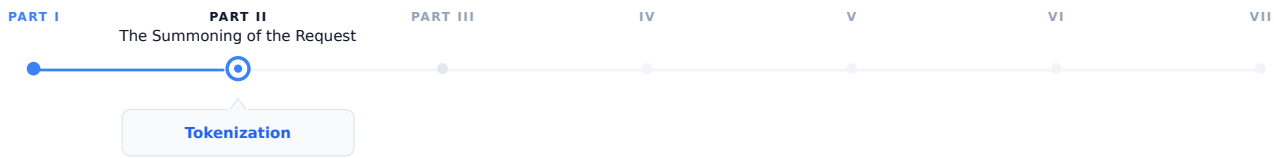

Figure 4.1: The journey through the Model Mind.

The request has arrived at the inference server. Before the model sees a single character, the text must be converted to numbers. This chapter covers that conversion in both directions and describes everything that can go wrong in between.

4.1 Two tokenization chapters, two different problems

If you read the training section first, you have already seen tokenization as in a batch preprocessing environment which means a corpus is tokenized once, offline, before training begins. The vocabulary is fixed. The inputs are known and errors are caught early.

Tokenization at inference is a different story. It runs on arbitrary user input, in real time, and on every request. It supposed to handle every string a user might type which could be multilingual text, source code, emoji, adversarial inputs, or a combination of all four. The encoded output feeds directly into a running model. The decoded output appears on a user's screen, sometimes token by token while they watch.

The concerns here are mostly operational, not theoretical. Understanding them is the difference between shipping reliable LLM applications or debugging corruption failures at 2am.

4.2 The encoding pipeline

When a request arrives, the first operation is encoding: converting the messages array into a flat sequence of token IDs ready for the model. This happens in two steps that are easy to confuse but are conceptually different.

4.2.1 Step 1: chat template application

The messages array has structure which includes roles, turns, and system prompts. The model has no concept of a dictionary. Before tokenization, the structured input must be flattened into a single string using a chat template.

Each model family has its own template. For LLaMA 3:

```
<|begin_of_text|>
<|start_header_id|>system<|end_header_id|>

You are a helpful assistant.<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>user<|end_header_id|>

What is the capital of France?<|eot_id|>
<|start_header_id|>assistant<|end_header_id|>
```

For Mistral:

```
<s>[INST] What is the capital of France? [/INST]
```

For ChatML (OpenAI and many others):

```
<|im_start|>system
You are a helpful assistant.<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>user
What is the capital of France?<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>assistant
```

The special tokens (`<|begin_of_text|>`, `<|eot_id|>`, `<|im_start|>`) are part of the model's vocabulary and were added during fine-tuning. The model learns to associate these markers with role transitions. Feeding the wrong template to the model causes it to sees an unexpected token sequence which in turn may cause the model to ignore the system prompt, and fail to complete the turn correctly, or produces outputs that look almost right but are systematically wrong in ways that can be hard to diagnose. This is one of the most common sources of bugs: no error is thrown yet the model just quietly misbehaves.

4.2.2 Step 2: token encoding

Once the flat string is constructed, the tokenizer converts it to integer IDs. This is a deterministic step in which the same string always produces the same IDs given the same tokenizer.

```python
messages = [
    {"role": "system", "content": "You are a helpful assistant."},
    {"role": "user",   "content": "What is the capital of France?"}
]

# Step 1: flatten with chat template
flat_string = apply_chat_template(messages, tokenizer)
# → "<|im_start|>system\nYou are a helpful assistant.<|im_end|>\n..."

# Step 2: convert to integers
token_ids = tokenizer.encode(flat_string)
# → [151644, 8948, 198, 2610, 525, 264, 10950, 17847, 13, ...]

# Step 3: pass to model
logits = model.forward(token_ids)
```

The tokenizer runs on CPU and for typical prompt lengths it is fast enough to be negligible relative to model inference time. On the other hand, for very long prompts (100k+ tokens) it can become measurable and there are some inference frameworks that cache tokenized system prompts to avoid repeating this work on every request.

4.2.3 Special tokens that require explicit handling

Several special tokens need attention beyond the template:

Beginning of sequence (BOS). Many models expect a BOS token at position 0 and the tokenizer typically adds it automatically while some serving configurations require manual insertion. A missing BOS token causes silent quality degradation which means the model's input distribution does not match training, and early tokens may be erratic.

End of turn markers. The template includes tokens marking the end of each turn and it must appear in the correct positions or the model misidentifies role boundaries.

Tool call tokens. Models fine-tuned for function calling have additional special tokens called tool call syntax. These must be in the tokenizer vocabulary and correctly placed in the template.

The generation prompt. The template typically ends with the opening of the assistant turn (e.g., `<|im_start|>assistant\n`) without closing it. This will signal the model that it should continue from here and omitting it causes the model to generate an incorrect turn structure.

4.3 Token continuation and context window management

The context window is the maximum sequence length the model can process in a single forward pass which is typically a range between 8k to 128k tokens for current models. Managing what fits in this window is a critical operational concern.

4.3.1 Count with the tokenizer, not your intuition

Token counts are not characters divided by four, or words divided by 0.75. They are the actual output of the tokenizer on the specific input string. Heuristics are inaccurate enough to cause real failures:

- Code tokenizes very differently from prose which means identifiers, operators, and whitespace have their own patterns
- Non-English text is often less efficient than English for most tokenizers
- Special tokens (role markers, tool tokens) add counts that character estimates miss entirely

Every production system that needs to stay within a context window must count tokens using the actual tokenizer, not an approximation:

```python
import tiktoken

enc = tiktoken.encoding_for_model("gpt-4o")

def count_tokens(messages: list[dict]) -> int:
    num_tokens = 0
    for message in messages:
        num_tokens += 4  # role, content, separators overhead
        for value in message.values():
            num_tokens += len(enc.encode(value))
    num_tokens += 2  # reply priming tokens
    return num_tokens
```

The exact overhead is varied by model and template. Always validate against the API's reported token counts on a representative sample.

4.3.2 The context window budget

In a typical production request, the context window is shared between several competing claims:

```
Total context window (e.g., 128k tokens)
   System prompt              (fixed, e.g., 500-2,000 tokens)
   Conversation history       (grows with each turn)
   Retrieved context (RAG)    (variable, e.g., 2,000-10,000 tokens)
   Current user message       (variable)
   Reserved for completion    (max_tokens parameter)
```

The sum must not exceed the window and if it does, the request will fail or the serving layer silently truncates something which is usually the earliest conversation history, that could be the exact context the user needs the most. Applications must actively manage this budget rather than hoping it fits.

Rolling window keeps only the most recent N tokens of history. While it is simple, it loses early context which can be fine for short tasks and problematic for long conversations.

Summarization uses the model to compress earlier turns into a compact representation when history approaches the limit. With this approach it preserves semantic content at the cost of an additional model call.

Hierarchical retrieval stores full history externally and only retrieve the most relevant portions for the current turn. This approach requires a retrieval component but it can scale to arbitrarily long conversations.

4.3.3 Prompt caching and its token implications

Some APIs (Anthropic's Claude, Google's Gemini) offer explicit prompt caching: mark a portion of the prompt as cacheable, and subsequent requests that share the same prefix reuse the KV cache from the first request, charged at a reduced rate.

For cost management, structure prompts with the stable content (system prompt, long documents) first and variable content (user messages, dynamic context) in the end. Token counting for cached prompts will distinguishs between newly processed tokens and cache-read tokens, as the API reports these separately and they have completely different cost implications.

4.4 The decoding pipeline: from numbers back to text

After the model selects the next token ID (the selection process is covered in chapter "REFF"), the serving layer converts that ID back to text. This is less straightforward than it appears.

4.4.1 Detokenization

The inverse operation: token IDs to string.

```python
token_ids = [15223, 374, 279, 6864, 315, 9822, 13]
text = tokenizer.decode(token_ids)
# → "Paris is the capital of France."
```

While it seems that detokenization simply involves looking up each token's string and concatenating them together, several complications exist:

Byte-level BPE and UTF-8 reconstruction. In byte-level tokenizers, tokens represent raw bytes rather than complete characters. Because UTF-8 characters are able to span multiple bytes, a single character (many Chinese characters or emojis) may be splited across several tokens. Decoding each token independently can therefore produce invalid text or replacement symbols. The correct procedure is to concatenate all token bytes first and then perform a single UTF-8 decode, ensuring the original characters are correctly reconstructed.

Special tokens in output. If the model produces a special token (end of text, role marker, tool call token), detokenization must strip it, convert it to a meaningful representation, or treat it as a halt signal. Which action is correct totally depends on context and must be handled explicitly.

4.4.2 Streaming detokenization

In streaming mode, tokens arrive one at a time and must be decoded incrementally which creates a specific problem: a byte sequence that spans multiple tokens cannot be decoded until all of its bytes have arrived.

Consider a Chinese character requiring 3 UTF-8 bytes, split across three tokens of 1 byte each:

- After token 1: 1 byte received and it is not a valid UTF-8 codepoint yet and cannot emit
- After token 2: 2 bytes received and it is still incomplete
- After token 3: 3 bytes received finally it is completed, decode and emit the character

A streaming decoder must buffer incomplete byte sequences and emit characters only once a complete Unicode codepoint is available. A naive implementations that pass `errors="ignore"` or `errors="replace"` will silently corrupt non-ASCII output while the HuggingFace `TextStreamer` and similar utilities handle this correctly.

4.5 Logprobs and their uses at inference time

Most APIs can optionally return the log probabilities of generated tokens which is more useful than it might initially appear.

4.5.1 What logprobs tell you

For each generated token, logprobs report the log probability the model assigned to the chosen token, and optionally the top-k alternatives with their probabilities:

```
{
  "token": "Paris",
  "logprob": -0.0023,
  "top_logprobs": [
    {"token": "Paris", "logprob": -0.0023},
    {"token": "Lyon",  "logprob": -6.12},
    {"token": "Nice",  "logprob": -7.88}
  ]
}
```

A logprob of -0.0023 means the model assigned probability `exp(-0.0023)  0.998` to this token which means the model is essentially certain. A logprob of -6.12 means `exp(-6.12)  0.002` and represent a distant second choice.

4.5.2 Classification without generation

For binary or multiple-choice tasks, logprobs let you skip generating a full response and instead read the probabilities of specific tokens directly which is faster and cheaper:

```
response = client.completions.create(
    model="gpt-4o",
    prompt=f"{text}\n\nIs this sentiment positive? Answer with yes or no.",
    max_tokens=1,
    logprobs=True,
    top_logprobs=5
)

top = response.choices[0].logprobs.top_logprobs[0]
yes_logprob = next(t.logprob for t in top if t.token.strip().lower() == "yes")
no_logprob  = next(t.logprob for t in top if t.token.strip().lower() == "no")
```

```
is_positive = yes_logprob > no_logprob
```

4.5.3 Calibration and uncertainty estimation

The perplexity of a generated response which is represented by the average negative log probability per token is a rough proxy for the model's confidence:

```
import numpy as np

logprobs = [token.logprob for token in response.choices[0].logprobs.content]
perplexity = np.exp(-np.mean(logprobs))
# High perplexity → model was uncertain about this response
```

This is not a hallucination detector which means the model can be confidently wrong, and often is. But it is a useful routing signal: responses with high perplexity can be flagged for human review or follow-up verification without running a separate evaluation model.

4.6 Common failure modes

Tokenization at inference produces specific, reproducible failure patterns. Knowing them saves significant debugging time.

Wrong tokenizer for the model. Using the GPT-2 tokenizer with a LLaMA model produces completely wrong token ID sequences. The model interprets unrelated IDs as completely different tokens which in turn leads to a garbage output.

Wrong chat template. Applying the wrong template produces subtly wrong token sequences. The model may ignore the system prompt, continue the user turn instead of starting an assistant turn, or generate role labels as content. This also fails silently and is especially confusing because outputs look almost right but are systematically off.

BOS token doubling. Some serving frameworks add BOS automatically while some expect the caller to add it. If BOS appears twice, the model sees an unexpected sequence at position 0 and may behave erratically.

Context overflow without truncation. If the total token count exceeds the context window and the serving layer does not truncate explicitly, some APIs return an error while some silently truncate from the beginning.

Encoding/decoding asymmetry. `decode(encode(s))` may not equal `s` for strings containing Unicode normalization differences, special tokens with non-standard decoding, or whitespace that the tokenizer normalizes.

4.7 Key takeaways

- Chat template application: flattening the messages array into a string with model-specific role delimiters it happens before tokenization and is model-specific; the wrong template produces silent quality degradation
- Token counting must use the actual tokenizer, not character or word heuristics; accurate counting is essential for context window management and cost control
- The context window budget must be actively managed across system prompt, conversation history, retrieved context, and completion reservation
- Streaming detokenization must buffer incomplete UTF-8 byte sequences and emit characters only once a complete codepoint is available; naive implementations corrupt non-ASCII output
- Stop sequence detection operates on decoded strings, not token IDs, and must handle sequences that span token boundaries and appear at buffer edges

- Token healing solves the boundary problem for prompts ending at arbitrary character positions, improving completion quality for structured generation
- Logprobs enable efficient classification, uncertainty estimation, and confidence- based routing without generating full responses

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4.8 Further reading

- HuggingFace Tokenizers documentation: Fast tokenizers and chat templates.
- OpenAI Cookbook: How to count tokens with tiktoken.
- HuggingFace (2023): Chat Templating Guide.

← Previous: 03 — APIs and model serving
Next: 05 — Context windows →

Tokenization at Inference, Cheat Sheet

Encoding Pipeline

1. Apply chat template → flatten structured messages

`<system> ... <user> ... <assistant>`

2. Tokenizer converts text → token IDs

`"Paris is capital" → [1512, 374, 279]`

Critical Special Tokens

- BOS token must exist at position 0
- End-of-turn markers define roles
- Tool tokens required for function calling
- Assistant prompt signals generation start

Context Window Budget

System prompt
Conversation history
RAG context
User message + completion tokens
Always count tokens using tokenizer, never estimate.

History Management Strategies

Rolling window → keep recent tokens only
Summarization → compress earlier turns
Hierarchical retrieval → fetch relevant past context

Decoding Pipeline

Model outputs token IDs → detokenizer reconstructs UTF-8 text

`[15223, 374, 279] → "Paris is the capital"`

Byte-level tokenizers require buffering before emitting characters.

Streaming Decoding

- Tokens arrive one at a time
- Partial UTF-8 bytes must be buffered
- Emit text only when character completes

Logprobs Uses

- Confidence estimation
- Classification without generation
- Perplexity ≈ uncertainty signal

Common Failure Modes

- Wrong tokenizer for model
- Wrong chat template → silent quality loss
- Double BOS token
- Context overflow / silent truncation
- encode(decode(x)) != x due to normalization

Figure 4.2: Cheat sheet.

Part III

Beyond the Gate of Words

Part IV

In the Halls of the Thinking Machine

Part V

The Forbidden Archive

Part VI

The Crafting of Intelligence

Part VII

The Trial of the Answer

Part VIII

Where Systems Walk Among Men

[1] G.-I. Yu, J. S. Jeong, G.-W. Kim, S. Kim, and B.-G. Chun, "Orca: A distributed serving system for {transformer-based} generative models," in *16th USENIX symposium on operating systems design and implementation (OSDI 22)*, 2022, pp. 521–538.